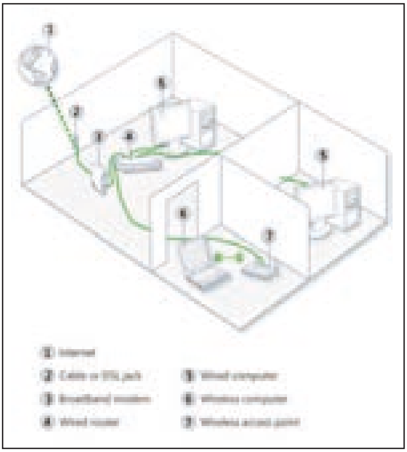

Network with a Wired Router and Access Point

network (LAN) to the wide area network (WAN) of the internet. By maintaining configuration information in a piece of storage called the routing table, wired or wireless routers also have the ability to filter traffic, either incoming or outgoing, based on the IP addresses of senders and receivers. Some routers allow the home networker to update the routing table from a web browser interface. Broadband routers combine the functions of a router with those of a network switch and a firewall in a single unit.

Access points

Access points, also known as base stations, are capable of providing wireless access to a wired ethernet network. An access point can be plugged into a hub, switch or wired router and can then be used to send out wireless signals. This enables computers and devices to connect to a wired network wirelessly.

In principle, access points act a lot like cellular phone towers. Just like you can move from one location to another and still make and receive calls, you can move around and continue to have wireless access to a network. When you use a public wireless network in an airport, coffee shop or hotel to connect to the internet, you're usually connecting through an access point. If you want to connect your computers wirelessly and have a router that provides wireless capability, you don't need an access point. Keep in mind that access points don't have built-in technology for sharing internet connections. So if you have to share an internet connection, you must plug an access point into a router or a modem with a built-in router.

Although very small WLANs can function without access points in so-called "ad hoc" or peer-to-peer mode, access points support "infrastructure" mode. This mode bridges WLANs with a wired ethernet LAN and also scales the network to support more clients. Older and base model access points allowed a maximum of only 10 or 20 clients; many newer access points support up to 255 clients.